CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

VENDING / ATM ROUTE OWNER IN THE AI ERA

Small machines, small tickets, quiet money — if the locations are right.

★ **TL;DR — Around $45K a year as a route owner, startable in 1–6 months with a handful of machines. The catch: the business is locations, and good locations are a sales job, not a purchase.** ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

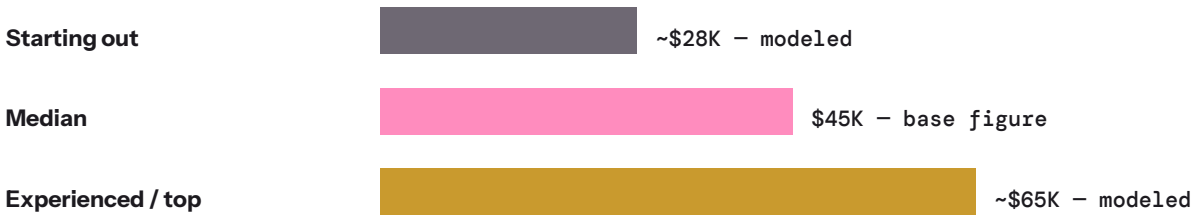
OUR TAKE: YES — WITH EYES OPEN

MEDIAN ~$45K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK LOW

- Machines earn while you sleep — but only in places with real foot traffic.
- The route, not the machine, is the asset: a placed machine with a happy location owner is worth more than a new machine in a garage.
- Cash handling, restocking and breakdowns keep it from ever being fully passive.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Vending / ATM Route Owner is a ~$45K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A VENDING / ATM ROUTE OWNER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Restock vending machines and service ATMs on a set route
- ✓ Collect cash, count inventory and track what actually sells
- ✓ Clean, fix and swap machines that underperform or break
- ✓ Pitch new locations and keep existing location owners happy

Think: a tiny landlord whose tenants are snack machines — rent is paid in coins and card taps.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Software now watches stock levels, sales patterns and machine health remotely, so routes get planned by data instead of habit. Card and mobile payments keep shrinking the cash side.	Locations are won in person. Reading a break room, convincing an office manager, noticing the warehouse that just hired forty people — that is local knowledge no dashboard hands you.

⚠ **A machine in a bad spot earns nothing and still costs you the trip. Location contracts, theft, vandalism and pricey repairs eat beginners who buy machines before they have places to put them.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Flexible hours — routes run when you say they run ✓ No staff, no storefront, no boss ✓ Grows one machine at a time, at your pace	✗ Driving, lifting cases and fixing jams in person ✗ Cash counting and coin runs to the bank ✗ Income is a hundred small drips, not a paycheck

Good fit? A methodical local operator who likes routes, numbers and negotiating with small businesses — and who will secure locations before buying hardware.
Bad fit? You believed the 'fully passive income' ad and never want to lift a case of soda or ask a stranger for placement space.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — BUY AN EXISTING ROUTE	DOOR B — PLACE MACHINES YOURSELF

The safer start: buy a small placed route from an operator who is retiring or moving. You pay more per machine, but the locations, sales history and relationships come with it — verify the numbers by riding the route before you sign.	Start with one or two machines and pitch locations directly: offices, warehouses, salons, car washes, apartment buildings. Cheaper to start, slower to earn — your real job for the first months is location sales.

Smart move: Sell the location owner, not the machine: offer a profit share, free service for their staff room, or a charity-donation hook. A signed location with mediocre traffic beats a great machine with nowhere to go.

Where you land after: A route big enough to hire a part-time restocker — or a route worth selling to the next operator.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
LEARN THE	CHOOSE YOUR	SECURE LOCATIONS	BUY AND	BUILD THE	GROW OR

STEP 1 — Learn the math on paper first

FREE · 1 WEEK

- Model one machine honestly: product cost, location share, your drive time, payment fees.
- If the numbers only work with fantasy sales, the location is wrong — not the spreadsheet.

STEP 2 — Choose your machine mix

FREE · 1 WEEK

- Snack and drink vending is the classic start; ATMs are a different cash and compliance game — pick one lane first.
- Card readers are not optional anymore: cash-only machines leave sales on the table.

STEP 3 — Secure locations before hardware

FREE · 2-4 WEEKS

- List 30 nearby workplaces with staff who cannot leave for lunch — warehouses, depots, offices, salons.
- Pitch in person, agree placement terms in writing, then buy machines for signed spots only.

STEP 4 — Buy and place the first machines

$1,500-5,000 PER MACHINE · 2-4 WEEKS

- Buy solid used machines from local sellers you can test in person before paying.
- Register the business, sort sales-tax and local permit requirements for your area.

STEP 5 — Build the route rhythm

PAID · FROM PLACEMENT

- Set a fixed route day, stock by sales data, and pull slow sellers without sentimentality.
- Track every machine separately: sales, costs, trips. Kill or move the bottom performers.

STEP 6 — Grow or prune deliberately

MONTH 3+

- Add machines only into proven location types; ask happy location owners for referrals and second sites.
- Every quarter, decide: this route grows, holds, or gets sold — on numbers, not hope.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: run the honest one-machine math and list 30 candidate locations near you.
- □ Days 1–30: pitch locations in person, sign your first placements, buy machines only for signed spots.
- □ Days 31–60: place and stock the first machines, set your route day, start the per-machine spreadsheet.
- □ Days 61–90: swap slow products, move or drop dead machines, pitch the second wave of locations.
- □ Day 90: a small working route with real numbers — now you know exactly what one more machine is worth.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **LOCATIONS FIRST. MACHINES SECOND.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.